School Closure Report

Buckman Elementary School

Date: 11/17/2026

School Closure Process
The PPS Board of Education determines whether schools will be closed. Board determination on school closures is based on the Superintendent's recommendation. The School Initiation & Closure policy (6.10.030-P) requires that the Superintendent's recommendation be accompanied by a School Closure Report.

If you have questions about this process or this report, please contact:

Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations
Margaret Calvert, Executive Director of School Planning and Modernization
501 N Dixon, Portland, OR 97227 | 503-916-2000

1. School Profile

School Name
Buckman Elementary School

Administrator
Lisa Ditto

Location
320 SE 16th Ave, Portland OR

Grade levels served
K-5

1a. School Description

Buckman Elementary School is a K–5 neighborhood and arts focus-option school in inner Southeast Portland, serving neighborhood students and students admitted through the PPS lottery. Its arts-integrated program provides visual arts, music, and dance instruction for all students. The school also houses regional Social Emotional Skills classrooms serving grades K–2 and 3–5. The Buckman campus has 28 classrooms and approximately 240 students are enrolled for the 2026-27 school year.

1b. Financial Impact

The primary financial benefit of consolidating elementary schools and programs is to align school capacity and operating costs with enrollment, allowing PPS to concentrate limited resources in fewer, more efficiently resourced schools. Combining school communities can reduce duplicative school-level administrative and operating expenses, improve building utilization, and support more efficient staffing and program delivery. These consolidations are intended to generate ongoing savings while supporting strong core instructional programs and student services.

If the school remains open, the projected cost per student for the 2027/2028 school year is: $21,616.

If the school is closed in 2027, the projected overall savings is $934,719. This includes savings from administrative, custodial, and office staffing, 80% of utilities, and includes the one-time cost of teacher moves. We anticipate ongoing expenses, including 20% of current utility costs and an average annual security cost, if the school were closed and unoccupied.

Under the proposed change, 36% of students would live more than one mile from Sunnyside and would be offered school bus transportation. To accommodate these students, PPS anticipates increasing service to Sunnyside Elementary from zero to three buses.

Under the proposed change, 44% of students would live more than one mile from Abernethy and would be offered school bus transportation. To accommodate these students, PPS anticipates maintaining service to Abernethy with four buses. The Transportation Department estimates an additional cost of approximately $50,000.

Transportation and Safe Routes to School planning will identify needed supports for safe arrival and dismissal, including walking and biking improvements, crossing supports, or traffic circulation changes.

1c. Student Enrollment

Table 1. Projected enrollment over the next five years, if school remains open:

School Year	2027-28	2028-29	2029-30	2030-31	2031-32
Students Enrolled	244	245	248	246	239

History of Requested and Actual Transfers
During 2024-25, 2025-26, and 2026-27 school years, 334 students requested transfers into Buckman and 92 enrolled through an approved transfer. During the same period, 151 students residing within the school's attendance area requested transfers to other schools, and 61 enrolled elsewhere through an approved transfer.

Projected declining enrollment will make it difficult to maintain stable staffing, full programming, and essential student support services. Under enrollment-based staffing allocations, low enrollment can result in year-to-year staffing changes, blended-grade classrooms or combined programs, and reduced access to enrichment and student support offerings. Staff may serve multiple roles or split time across schools, limiting continuity and availability. While educators would continue working to meet students' needs, projected enrollment would constrain the school's ability to provide consistent access to a well-rounded educational experience without ongoing supplemental district resources.

2. School Facilities and Student Reassignment

2a. School Description

Built	Building size	Stories	Acres
1921	74,161 sq ft	2	4.86
Building condition	**Gross capacity**	**Functional capacity**	**Cost of school operations**
Poor; FCI 0.19	771 students	633 students	$5,295,940

Gross capacity is the estimated maximum number of students a school can accommodate, calculated by assigning a student capacity to each classroom based on its square footage and summing those capacities:

- Less than 800 square feet: 24 students
- 800–1,000 square feet: 27 students
- More than 1,000 square feet: 30 students

Functional capacity is a practical estimate of the number of students a school can accommodate, calculated by multiplying its gross capacity by the applicable utilization rate. It does not represent maximum occupancy under building code requirements or determine

staffing levels.

The cost of school operations includes projected FY28 school-based costs in funds 100 and 200 plus Facilities, Nutrition Services, and Special Education, at the current service level.

Physical Condition of Building, Capital and Environmental Needs
Situated in the Buckman neighborhood of Southeast Portland, the 1921 Buckman Elementary School is over 100 years old, and in poor condition with a facility condition index (FCI) score of 0.19. Facility assessments identified cracking in the south exterior concrete wall and southwest retaining wall; cracked or deteriorating concrete stairs; roof-hatch deterioration; loose and cracked cafeteria flooring; and delaminating wood floors in the cafeteria and gymnasium. The 2021 Long Range Facilities Plan also identified classroom temperature-control problems, aging mechanical equipment, and undersized classrooms and shared spaces. Furthermore, there are structural issues that would need to be addressed if the school continued to be open.

ADA Accessibility
The first floor is accessible through a ramp near the main entrance and there is an elevator that provides access to the basement and second-floor classrooms.

Building Use
Currently, Buckman houses a K–5 neighborhood school and an arts focus-option program, including visual arts, music, and dance instruction, as well as regional K–2 and 3–5 Social Emotional Skills classrooms.

Analysis of current and potential use of the facility, including recommended disposition
Following closure, potential uses of the Buckman Elementary School facility will be evaluated through the district's Building Repurposing Plan, informed by community engagement, district needs, facility conditions, and financial considerations. This process will consider opportunities to support students and the surrounding community and identify a recommended future use or disposition for Board consideration.

2b. Student Reassignment

The proposed closure of Buckman Elementary School would reassign neighborhood K–5 students to Abernethy and Sunnyside and discontinue the arts focus-option program. The neighborhood boundary would be divided approximately in half: the area north of Hawthorne and south of Burnside would be assigned to Abernethy, and the area north of Burnside would be assigned to Sunnyside. Students currently served in Buckman's K–2 and 3–5 Social Emotional Skills (SES) classrooms would receive services in dedicated SES classrooms at Sunnyside.

Proposed Attendance Boundary
See attached map.

Transportation options and barriers
Transportation options include walking, biking, family transportation, and school bus service for elementary students who live more than one mile from their neighborhood school; additional students may qualify based on Oregon Department of Education guidelines or individual needs.

We do not anticipate any barriers to students getting to school; however, additional bussing may be provided, as needed, for hazard areas within the school attendance boundary.

How will this school location accommodate the reassigned students?
Sunnyside has 24 classrooms and a functional capacity of 492 students. With a combined enrollment of 480 in 2027/2028, Sunnyside will be able to accommodate the reassigned students.

Abernethy has 21 classrooms and a functional capacity of 449 students. With a combined enrollment of 312, Abernethy will be able to accommodate the reassigned students.

Recommendation
PPS recommends closing Buckman Elementary School and discontinuing its arts focus-option program for the 2027–2028 school year. Neighborhood K–5 students would be assigned to Abernethy or Sunnyside according to the proposed attendance boundaries. Students served in Buckman's K–2 and 3–5 Social Emotional Skills classrooms would receive services in dedicated SES classrooms at Sunnyside, consistent with their IEP-identified needs.

3. Community/Cluster and District Impact Analysis

3a. Cluster Analysis

How will the proposed closure maintain or improve equity of access to schools offering high quality educational choices?
In the 2026-2027 school year, PPS staffs and supports 56 elementary programs. Eleven of these programs are situated within K-8 campuses. The enrollment of these programs ranges from 160 students to over 550 students. Using the QEM and our system definition of "well-resourced schools" as a guide, we have established an elementary enrollment of 360 as the minimum threshold to be able to staff and support a comprehensive and stable elementary program. Maximizing the number of sites at or above this minimum threshold allows the district to maximize the number of students who experience grade-level classrooms, comprehensive core enrichments, and targeted academic supports. It also maximizes the number of educators who work full-time on one campus and who benefit from regular collaboration with grade- and content-alike colleagues.

By operating fewer elementary schools and spreading current enrollment more evenly across remaining sites, the district can stabilize and offer a more comprehensive and sustainable program at each elementary site.

In recent years, we have used resources from other parts of our system to subsidize elementary programs with low enrollment. Given our current and projected budget shortfalls, we can no longer sustain subsidies for underenrolled sites. As a result, elementary schools have already faced several programmatic and operational constraints:

- Over half of our elementary programs have been forced to place students in multi-grade classrooms;
- Staffing for instructional coaching, academic coaching, and school climate support positions have been reduced;
- Core enrichment teachers that support Arts, PE, and Library/Media instruction have been split across multiple sites, reducing the capacity to have full-school enrichment programs;
- Support staff that help monitor lunch and recess have been reduced, forcing principals to spend much of their time monitoring duty;
- Opportunities for strong teacher collaboration and professional learning have been compromised by multi-grade classrooms and single-strand programs.

If we continue with no rightsizing action, all of these constraints will be compounded in school year 27-28.

3b. Effects on Other Schools, Enrollment, and Community Access

The proposed merger would affect Sunnyside School and Abernethy Elementary School. Enrollment at Sunnyside is projected to change from 485 (as a K-8) to 480 (as a K-5) in the 2027–2028 school year. Based on current enrollment projections, Sunnyside will have two to three classrooms at each grade-level, with blends not required. Enrollment at Abernethy is projected to change from 269 to 312 in the same year. At Abernethy, based on current enrollment projections, there will be two to three classrooms at each grade-level, with blends not required. These changes would support combined elementary school communities, with opportunities to stabilize staffing and sustain educational programs and student supports. Implementation would require coordinated staffing, classroom assignments, and use of shared spaces, along with support for students transitioning from Buckman's arts-integrated program into another program with an environmental focus. Receiving-school readiness needs at Sunnyside include minor kitchen upgrades, including a warming cabinet, and a recommended steam pipe assessment. Abernethy requires moderate kitchen upgrades, including a double oven, double-door freezer, and warming oven, as well as further evaluation and remediation of groundwater conditions in the playground area affecting the additional classrooms northeast of the main building, where the former portables were located. These improvements would support incoming students while maintaining services for students already enrolled.

Buckman Elementary School is located approximately 1.4 miles from Sunnyside and 1.4 miles from Abernethy. Nearby community resources include Belmont Library in the Sunnyside area and Piccolo Park near Abernethy. The proposed change would shift students' daily school activities toward their assigned receiving school. Transportation options include walking, biking, family transportation, and school bus service for eligible students. PPS would evaluate needs through transportation eligibility and route reviews, coordination with school-based childcare providers, and Safe Routes to School planning to identify appropriate crossing, pedestrian, and bicycle safety measures.

3c. Community Partnerships and Potential Community Impact

Buckman currently partners with Friends of the Children to provide long-term mentoring for students. Closure is not expected to interrupt this service. Friends of the Children has a long-term commitment to each child regardless of school placement, and mentors (referred to as Friends) continue supporting students when they transition to another school. These services are provided at no cost to the District. No Racial Equity & Social Justice (RESJ) partner services at Buckman have been identified as requiring alternatives. Additional community impacts include the adjustment for students and mentors as they reconnect in a new school setting, with proposed responses including coordinating with receiving schools so Friends can continue working with students without interruption.

Buckman currently partners with Champions to provide before- and after-school care for approximately 45 students. The program is expected to relocate to Sunnyside, which partners with the YMCA serving 48 students, and Abernethy, which partners with Art 4 Life serving 87 students. Adding Buckman's students would bring the combined enrollment across these programs to approximately 180 students, requiring careful consideration of available space, licensing, staffing, and operational capacity. We ask that Champions, the YMCA, Art 4 Life, and both receiving school administrations be included in early transition planning to determine how students will be divided, ensure sufficient appropriately licensed space, and minimize disruptions to existing programs and families. Clear communication about enrollment, program locations, transportation, and timelines will also be essential. A successful transition requires collaboration and adequate resources to accommodate Buckman families while preserving the services and partnerships already established at Sunnyside and Abernethy.

Buckman currently partners with Impact NW to operate its SUN Community School, providing community-based services and wraparound family supports through collaboration among PPS, Multnomah County, and the City of Portland. SUN provides free extended-day enrichment opportunities, access to a food pantry, individualized family support, and culturally relevant programming supported by staff who reflect and understand the student population. Buckman's enrichment offerings include arts and cultural programming such as Ballet the Black Way, Spanish language instruction, theater through Northwest Children's Theater, martial arts, sports, chess, music, creative writing, and STEM activities such as LEGO Mechanical Engineering. These opportunities provide students with access to experiences that support creativity, academic enrichment, physical activity, cultural learning, and social-emotional development. Closure could significantly disrupt student and family access to established SUN services, enrichment opportunities, trusted staff relationships, and community partnerships. Opportunities for partnerships to continue would require further coordination, as students would transition to Sunnyside and Abernethy, neither of which currently operates a SUN Community School. Unlike transitions to schools with an existing SUN program, there is no established SUN infrastructure at either receiving school to absorb Buckman's existing programming, staffing, partnerships, and family support services. Services requiring alternatives or further coordination include identifying how students and families will continue accessing wraparound supports, food pantry resources, individualized family assistance, free enrichment opportunities, and summer programming currently coordinated through Impact NW. Additional community impacts include the potential loss of an established access point for families navigating basic-needs

resources, disruption of community partnerships and enrichment providers, and reduced access to free developmental and academic opportunities that support student engagement and success.

Proposed responses include a coordinated district effort with Impact NW, Sunnyside and Abernethy school leadership, and community partners to identify students and families currently accessing Buckman SUN services, establish warm handoffs to alternative resources, assess opportunities to maintain existing enrichment partnerships and programming at other locations, and identify potential service gaps requiring additional staffing, funding, or alternative service delivery arrangements. Particular consideration should be given to preserving access to SUN services for families transitioning to both receiving schools and ensuring that students do not experience an interruption in access to essential resources and enrichment opportunities.

Any future community use of the facility would be considered through the Building Repurposing process.

3d. Operational Plan & Boundary Map

If approved, the closure would take effect in 2027, with students assigned to Sunnyside or Abernethy under the proposed boundaries shown in the attached boundary map.

Operational Implementation Plan

Timeline*	Action
January 2027	Establish school transition teams and school-specific implementation plans. Verify student enrollment. Share Principal assignments with communities.
February 2027	Develop staffing plans and confirm initial staff assignments. Identify and prioritize building improvements, equipment, and technology needs.
March 2027	Identify initial classroom assignments and develop school-specific moving schedules, distribute packing supplies, and begin records transfers.
April 2027	Begin packing and sorting materials not needed for daily instruction. Finalize plans for building improvements and technology setup.
May 2027	Confirm summer moving and building-work schedules. Continue packing and prepare materials for transportation and other operational services for receiving schools.
June 2027	Complete teacher packing. Begin school moves after the school year ends and carry out scheduled building improvements.

Timeline*	Action
July 2027	Continue school moves and building improvements. Install furniture, equipment, and technology at receiving schools.
August 2027	Complete scheduled moves by mid August. Finish cleaning, classroom setup, and technology testing.
September 2027	Monitor school operations and address remaining transition needs. Complete closing-building inventories.

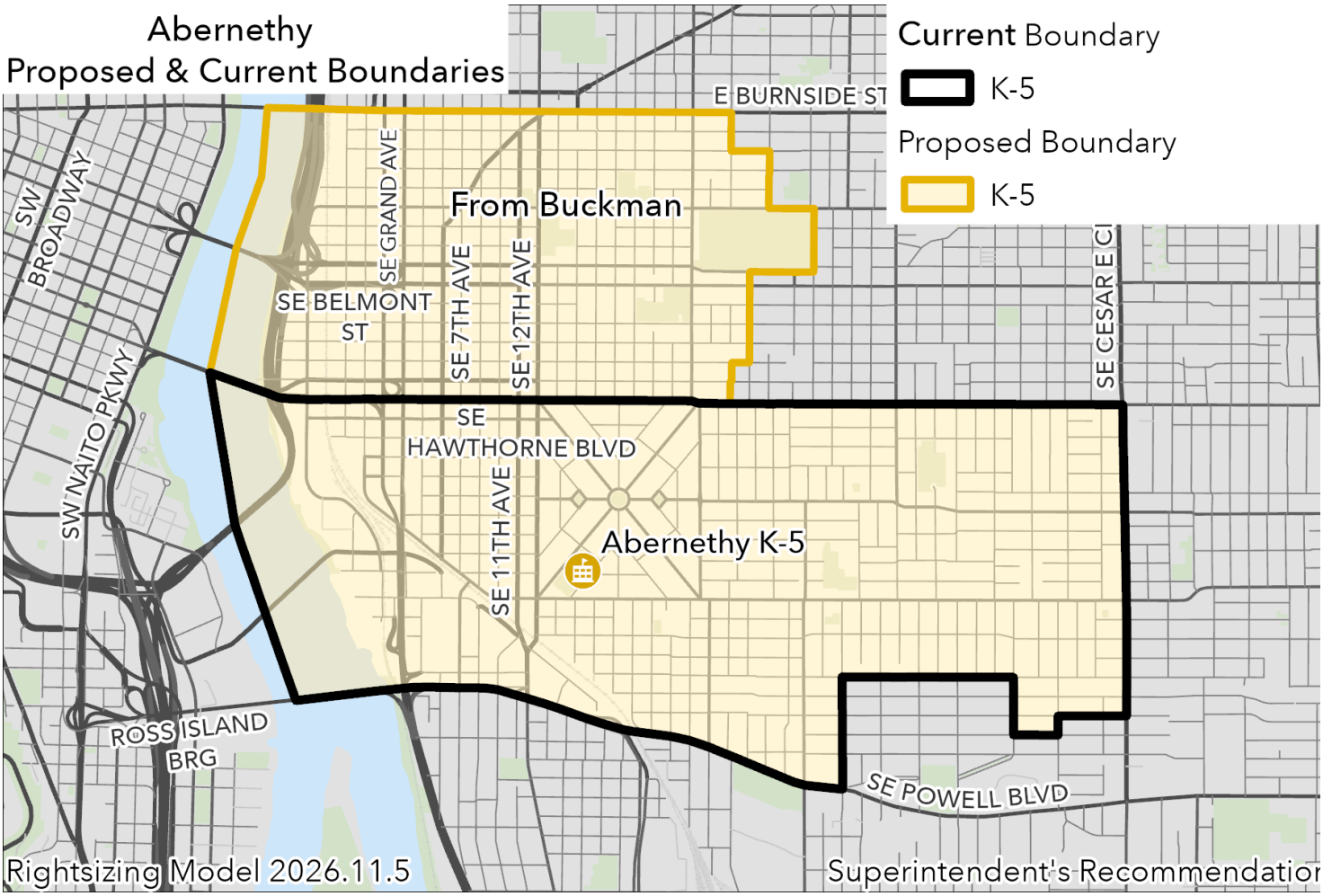
**Subject to change*

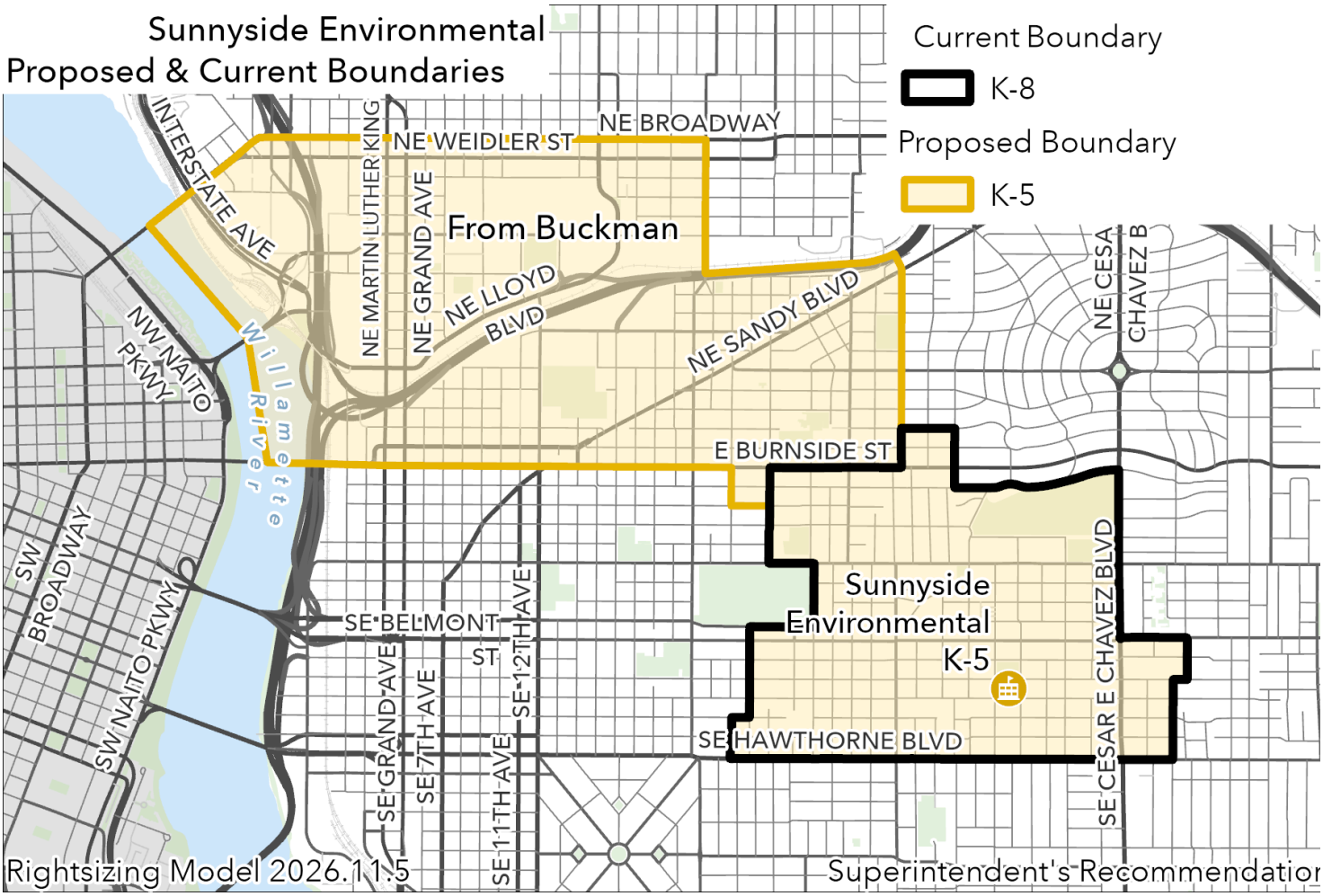
Review and Approval

This report has been reviewed by appropriate district staff.

Superintendent Signature

Date


Abernethy
Proposed & Current Boundaries
Current Boundary
K-5
Proposed Boundary
K-5
From Buckman
Abernethy K-5
E BURNSIDE ST
SW BROADWAY
SW NAITO PKWY
SE GRAND AVE
SE BELMONT ST
SE 7TH AVE
SE 12TH AVE
SE HAWTHORNE BLVD
SE 11TH AVE
SE CESAR E CI
ROSS ISLAND BRG
SE POWELL BLVD
Rightsizing Model 2026.11.5
Superintendent's Recommendation


Sunnyside Environmental
Proposed & Current Boundaries
Current Boundary
K-8
Proposed Boundary
K-5
From Buckman
Sunnyside
Environmental
K-5
INTERSTATE AVE
NE MARTIN LUTHER KING
NE WEIDLER ST
NE BROADWAY
NE GRAND AVE
NE LLOYD BLVD
NE SANDY BLVD
NE CESAR CHAVEZ BLVD
NW NAITO PKWY
Willamette River
E BURNSIDE ST
SW BROADWAY
SW NAITO PKWY
SE BELMONT ST
SE 12TH AVE
SE GRAND AVE
SE 7TH AVE
SE 11TH AVE
SE HAWTHORNE BLVD
SE CESAR E CHAVEZ BLVD
Rightsizing Model 2026.11.5
Superintendent's Recommendation